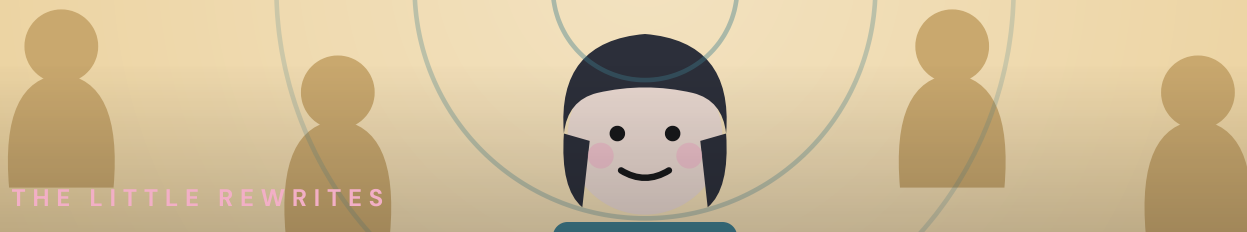


CLANG!

DRUMS!

BOOM!



THE LITTLE REWRITES

THE QUIETEST KID IN THE KINGDOM

A story about the loud, brave magic of a quiet heart.

MK PARRISH



In a kingdom that loved to be loud
there lived a girl named Posy.
And Posy was the quietest kid
anyone had ever met.

TRUMPETS!

BANG!

BOOM!

LOUDER!

CHEER!

HOORAY!

It was a kingdom of noise, and proud of it.
Trumpets at breakfast. Drums at lunch.
And at every festival, a great contest
to see who could cheer the loudest.
And Posy?

Posy sat at the back, and watched,
and said almost nothing at all.

An illustration of a child with dark hair and a purple headband, wearing a dark blue dress, standing in the center. Behind the child are four concentric circles, suggesting a listening range or a shell. Four stylized orange human figures are positioned around the child, representing other children in a crowd. The background is a light blue gradient at the top, fading into a darker blue gradient at the bottom.

While the other children filled the air with
words,
Posy filled herself with something else.
She *listened*.
She *noticed*.
She gathered the quiet things
the loud kingdom rushed right past —
the way some children gather shells.



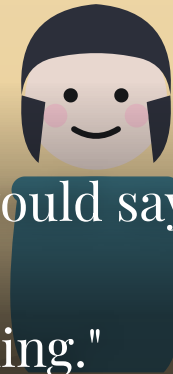
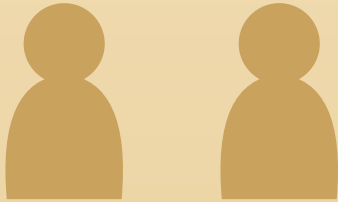
a sparrow, half a beat behind...

the wind, before the rain.

She heard the sparrow that sang
a half-beat behind all the others.
She saw which children were laughing,
and which were only pretending.
She knew the sound the wind made
just before the rain —
and the look on her mother's face
that meant *tired, but don't you worry.*



so quiet... you never know...



"She's so quiet," the grown-ups would say,
a little worried.

"You never know what she's thinking."

And that was true. They never did.

It simply never occurred to them
to sit down beside her and find out.



Now, the loudest thing in all the kingdom
was the Great Bell.

It hung in the tower at the center of town,
and its ring was so enormous, so magnificent,
it could be heard in every corner of the land.

The whole kingdom loved it.

The whole kingdom was, in a way, built around
it.



And one gray morning, the Great Bell went silent.

The bell-ringer pulled the rope,
and instead of the magnificent ring
there came only a dull, cracked *thunk*.

The bell was broken, somewhere deep inside
—

and no one could tell where.

"The crack could be *anywhere*," said the
craftsmen.

"It would take a year to find."

MELT IT!

START OVER!

LOUDER!

NO, YOU!

The whole kingdom crowded into the square,
everyone shouting over everyone else,
certain, as always, that the answer
was *more noise*.

And at the very back,
a small quiet voice said,
"I know where the crack is."

Nobody heard it.

It was, after all, a very loud square.



So Posy did the bravest thing she had ever
done.

She walked to the front.

She tugged the mayor's sleeve.

And when he bent down, she said it again,
just to him:

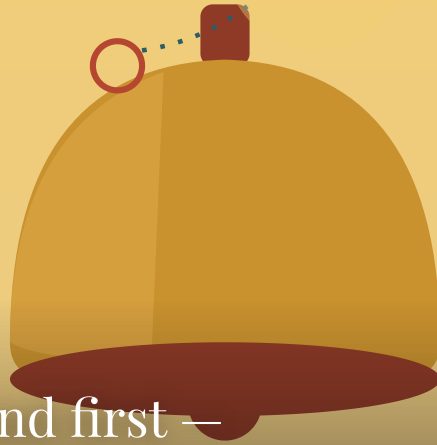
"I know where the crack is.

Because they were all talking.

And I was *listening*."



a little hiss, like a whisper...



"There's a tiny sound first —
a little hiss, like a whisper —
up near the top, on the left side,
where the sun hits in the morning.
I've heard it for weeks.
It's been getting louder.
That's where it's breaking.
You don't have to take the whole bell apart.
You just have to look *there*."



They climbed the tower,
to the top, on the left side, where the sun hits

and there, so fine you could barely see it,
was a hairline crack,
exactly where the quietest kid in the kingdom
said it would be.

They mended it in a single afternoon.
And the mayor crouched down beside Posy.
"We kept telling you to be *louder*," he said.
"But the kingdom didn't need another loud
voice.

It needed someone who was finally *listening*."

From that day on, when something went
wrong,
the loudest kingdom in the world
learned to do a brand-new thing.
It got quiet.
And it went and found Posy.
Because you cannot hear anything true
while you are shouting.
If you are a Posy:
your quiet is not empty. It is *full*.
You are listening —
and one day that will matter
more than all their noise combined.



FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

The world spends a lot of a child's early years telling them to speak up. Sometimes that's good advice. But the quiet ones aren't empty — they're often the ones noticing what everyone else is too loud to hear. This is a story for shy, introverted, and quiet children, and a gentle correction to the idea that quiet means less. When you finish, tell the quiet child beside you: your quiet is a kind of listening the loud world forgot how to do — and it's a strength, not a problem to fix.

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